FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Just a decade and a half ago, Naxals had such a vast, malignant presence across the country that then prime minister Dr Manmohan Singh described Left-wing Extremism (LWE) as "the greatest internal security threat to the nation". The Red Corridor, as it was called, sliced India vertically all the way from Pashupatinath in Nepal to Tirupati in Andhra Pradesh. On the Indian side, at its peak, this is estimated to have affected the lives of about 80 million people. In 2014, when the Modi government took charge, the Naxals had the upper hand in 126 districts spread across 10 states: Andhra Pradesh, Bihar, Chhattisgarh, Jharkhand, Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, Odisha, Telangana, West Bengal and Uttar Pradesh. Dr Singh unfailingly flagged its root cause: near-criminal levels of neglect of tribal India, worsened by loss of forest rights and displacement. Orphaned and disempowered, local communities had become the perfect soil for the anti-State and violent ideology of the Naxals to take root and flourish.

The challenge was complex at all levels. It was not easy to spread development to remote forest regions controlled by Kalashnikov-wielding militias, specialists in guerrilla warfare involving booby traps, land mines, ambushes and extensive gunbattles. In the past 20 years, 2,344 security personnel have lost their lives in the battle against Naxal insurgency—four times the number of Indian Army personnel killed in the Kargil War. Not counting the 6,000-plus civilians killed in related incidents during the same period.



Raj Chengappa (centre), Chandradeep Kumar (left) and Rahul Noronha in Bastar

How did New Delhi win over such a vast territory and its sullen social base? As Union home minister Amit Shah explains in an exclusive interview, the strategy was as nuanced as it was relentless, the objective being to "replace weapons and violence with development and trust". The Modi government finally broke the stalemate with a remarkable four-pronged strategy, employed in a concerted fashion after Shah took office in 2019.

The first thrust was ruthlessly dealing with those wedded to the gun. That meant laying out an elaborate security dragnet over the deepest jungles of central India to ensure area dominance. The government did this by setting up Forward Operating Bases (FOBs) in areas where the security vacuum had earlier enabled the Naxals to flourish. To get a ground perspective, Group Editorial Director Raj Chengappa travelled across the heart of the Bastar region along with Senior Associate Editor Rahul Noronha to many of these FOBs. Security personnel ferried them on motorcycles, which was the new protocol to avoid land mines. They found the bases manned by combat personnel with commando training and equipped with modern assault rifles that outgunned the Naxals. The FOBs are not just fortified garrisons, closed off from the surrounding landscape, they also serve as points of social outreach, running schools and health centres for the locals. In the past five years, 302 such bases were set up in the region and it was found to be the best way to consolidate territory.

The second prong was the induction of modern intelligence-gathering tools like drones and satellite imaging that helped track the movement of the rebels. The old guerrilla tactics of the Naxals stood no chance against contemporary surveillance and they were systematically driven out of their bastions. Fortified Police Stations were set up to hold ground ceded by the retreating rebels. Over 612 such stations have come up, showing the extent of turf taken. Choppers were on call at the FOBs to pump up the morale of the security forces with their capability for rapid operational movement and evacuation for medical emergencies. A generous surrender policy, meanwhile, thinned the insurgency. Almost 7,500 Naxals have surrendered in the past 10 years. Many of these former cadres joined the state forces and became "a force multiplier", enriching tech intelligence with vital human intelligence and local terrain knowledge.

The third mortal wound was severing the extortion funds and arms pipeline, squeezing cash flows by digitising the local economy. Once fitted, the last piece of the jigsaw could prove the most enduring. Areas cleared of Naxalism were endowed with much-needed development: over 11,503 km of roads, 2,343 mobile towers, and other harbingers of prosperity. As Shah says, the idea is to create a paradigm where "there is no reason for people to go back to Naxalism". What we termed as the Modi government's Guns and Gulab (roses) policy is a fitting conclusion to the longest insurrection against the Indian State, especially if it succeeds in Shah's plan to totally ridding the country of gun-toting Naxals by the spring of 2026.

(Aroon Purie)